Windshear Detection

How MODE-S Wind finds low-level windshear from the aircraft's own data, and how to read the Windshear page

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In short. Every aircraft on final approach to Helsinki-Vantaa answers the radar's Mode S interrogations with its true airspeed (TAS) and ground speed (GS). Their difference, TAS − GS, is the headwind the aircraft is flying into, measured about every two seconds. MODE-S Wind follows this headwind along each aircraft's path and looks for two things:

- a **headwind ramp** — a sudden loss or gain of headwind along the path of one aircraft, scaled to a 1-km equivalent so that a quick change counts more than a slow one (Section 3.4);
- a **change between flights** — the wind of the aircraft in each 200-ft height band compared with all landings and departures of the previous 45 minutes, which shows a front or a gust front arriving (Section 3.6).

The result is graded like the alerts of airport windshear systems: ADV advisory from 10 kt, WSA windshear alert from 15 kt and MBA microburst alert from a 30 kt loss. The detection runs on the server for every landing and departure, whether or not anyone has the page open; the Windshear page shows the alerts, a 24-hour alert log and a windshear report for every landing (Section 5).

An experimental research product. The alerts come from a passive receiver and describe air that an aircraft has *already* flown through. They are not an operational windshear warning, they are not certified, and they must not be used for flight operations or air traffic control. Use them to study the low-level wind at the airport and to compare with official reports.

Contents

1 What windshear is **2**

2 What the aircraft tell us **2**

3 The detector step by step **3**

3.1 Cleaning the replies . . . 3
3.2 Distance along the path . . . 3
3.3 Smoothing . . . 3
3.4 Headwind ramps . . . 3
3.5 Horizontal F-factor . . . 4
3.6 Change against the earlier flights (band comparison) . . . 5
3.7 Levels . . . 5
3.8 From an event to an alert . . . 6
3.9 A windshear report for every flight . . . 6

4 The scientific basis **6**

5 The Windshear page **7**

5.1 Banner, flight strips and ILS profile . . . 7
5.2 The alert log . . . 8
5.3 Approach History: the WS view . . . 8
5.4 The other panels . . . 9

6 Cases from October 2026 **10**

7 Limitations and good practice **11**

8 Quick reference **12**

1 What windshear is

Definition. Windshear is a change of the wind speed or direction over a short distance. For aviation the dangerous part is *low-level* windshear: ICAO defines the wind shear warnings of an aerodrome for the layer between the runway and 500 m (1 600 ft) above it, along the approach and take-off paths [1]. What matters to an aircraft is the change of the wind *along its own path*, in particular of the headwind: a headwind change of 15 kt or more, lasting longer than a gust, is usually regarded as significant [2, 3].

Why a loss of headwind is the hazard. An aircraft flies through the air, not over the ground. If the headwind suddenly drops by 20 kt, the airspeed drops by the same amount at that instant, while the ground speed stays the same. On a stabilised approach at 140 kt the wing then has 20 kt less airspeed and less lift, the aircraft sinks below the glide path, and the crew must add thrust and pitch up to recover. A **gain** of headwind does the opposite — the aircraft balloons above the path and speeds up; it is less dangerous but often comes just before a loss (the typical sequence in a microburst: headwind gain, downdraft, tailwind). Loss is therefore treated as the more serious direction, and only a loss can become a microburst alert.

The F-factor. NASA and the FAA combined both effects — the change of the horizontal wind and the downdraft — into one hazard index, the *F-factor* [4, 5]:

$$F = \frac{\dot{W}_x}{g} - \frac{w}{V}, \tag{1}$$

where $\dot{W}_x$ is the rate of change of the headwind *loss* along the path (m/s^2; a tailwind increase counts as positive), g the gravity, w the vertical wind (negative in a downdraft) and V the airspeed. F is the loss of the aircraft's climb capability expressed as a gradient: $F = 0.1$ means the shear takes away the equivalent of a 10 % climb gradient. Averaged over about **1 km** of path it best separates hazardous from harmless shear; the FAA considers windshear hazardous at $F > 0.1$ and uses 0.13 as the "must alert" level of airborne windshear systems [5].

What happens at Helsinki-Vantaa. Downbursts from thunderstorms occur in Finland mainly in summer. More common causes of low-level windshear at EFHK are *fronts* and *gust fronts* that change the wind within minutes, *low-level jets* and *inversions* that make the wind turn and increase sharply over a few hundred feet (often at night and in the morning), and strong, gusty winds in autumn and winter storms. The detector is built for all of these, not only for microbursts.

2 What the aircraft tell us

Mode S Enhanced Surveillance. The secondary radars around Helsinki interrogate each aircraft for registers that its transponder fills from the flight computers. MODE-S Wind receives the replies passively. Two registers matter here:

- **BDS 5,0** (track and turn report): roll angle, true track, ground speed, track rate and **true airspeed** — all from the same instant;
- **BDS 6,0** (heading and speed report): magnetic heading, indicated airspeed, Mach and the vertical rates.

On final approach an aircraft typically sends a BDS 5,0 reply about every two seconds, and a new value of TAS − GS about every four seconds, or every 290 m of path [12].

Headwind from one register. Within a single BDS 5,0 reply,

$$h = \mathrm{TAS} - \mathrm{GS} = W_x + \mathrm{TAS}\,(1 - \cos\beta), \tag{2}$$

where W_x is the headwind along the track and β the crab angle (heading minus track). No heading, magnetic declination or wind-vector calculation is involved, so none of their errors enter. Both speeds are rounded to 2 kt in the register; the resulting noise is about 1.1–1.2 kt per reply [12]. The crab term is about 2 kt at $\beta = 10$ and changes only slowly along an approach, so it cancels almost completely in a ramp.

The wind vector. With BDS 6,0 added, the full wind is the ground vector minus the air vector: wind = (GS, true track) − (TAS, true heading). The true heading is the magnetic heading plus the declination of the World Magnetic Model, corrected for each airframe's own heading offset, which MODE-S Wind learns continuously. The wind vectors are less precise than TAS − GS (a 1° heading error is about 2.5 kt of crosswind at 140 kt) but they can be compared between aircraft flying in different directions. Mode S derived winds of this kind have been validated against other observations in several studies [11].

Where the data end. The receiver near Tuusula sees the aircraft down to a few hundred feet: the lowest point followed is 476 ft above mean sea level on a median approach (about 300 ft above the runway), depending on the runway. The last

part of the approach and the landing roll are not seen. Turboprops send no Mach, and a few aircraft do not answer BDS 5,0 at all; they are simply not analysed.

3 The detector step by step

Figure 1 shows the chain from the replies to an alert. The same code (`collector/shear.py`) runs live on every aircraft on final, and once more over the whole approach when the landing is recorded.

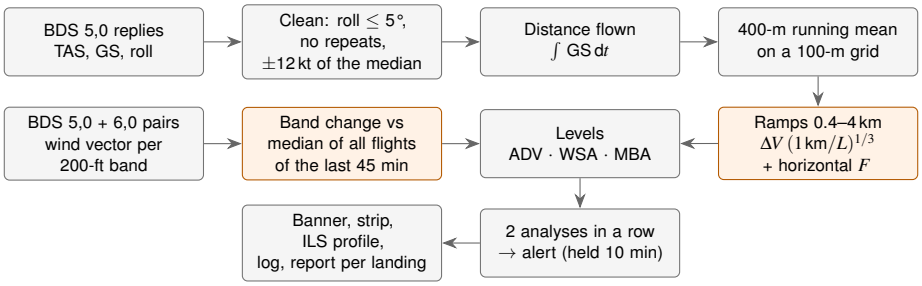


Figure 1. From the aircraft's replies to an alert. Top: the headwind ramp along the path of one aircraft (TAS − GS). Bottom: the change of the wind between flights (wind vectors). Both give a level; an event found in two analyses in a row becomes an alert.

3.1 Cleaning the replies

A reply is not used when the aircraft is banked more than 5° (in a turn the speeds and the track change quickly), when it repeats exactly the previous register content within 6 s (the transponder sent an old value again), or when TAS or GS are outside the plausible range. The remaining values are compared with their running median over ±7.5 s; a value more than 12 kt away from it is a corrupt reply and is dropped. The scatter of the accepted values about that median is the aircraft's own noise σ, used below for the significance test (1.24 kt on a median approach).

3.2 Distance along the path

A windshear ramp is a change over a *distance*, so the replies are placed along the path. The distance flown is the ground speed integrated over time,

$$x_k = x_{k-1} + \tfrac{1}{2}\,(\mathrm{GS}_{k-1} + \mathrm{GS}_k)\,(t_k - t_{k-1}), \tag{3}$$

not computed from the reported positions: positions freeze when GNSS is jammed, which happens regularly in this region, while the ground speed of BDS 5,0 comes from the inertial system and keeps running. Height is the barometric altitude of the tracker (ft above mean sea level).

3.3 Smoothing

The headwinds are averaged over 400 m of path (a running mean, at least two replies in the window) on a 100-m grid. This removes the reply noise and single gusts, which last only a few seconds, while keeping changes that extend over 400 m or more — the scales on which windshear affects a transport aircraft. Changes over less than about 400 m are deliberately smoothed out.

3.4 Headwind ramps

For every pair of grid points L apart, with L = 0.4, 0.6, 0.8, 1, 1.5, 2, 3 and 4 km, the detector takes the change of the smoothed headwind in the direction of flight,

$$\Delta V = \bar{h}(x+L) - \bar{h}(x) \qquad (\Delta V < 0\text{: loss, } \Delta V > 0\text{: gain}), \tag{4}$$

and scales it to a **1-km equivalent**

$$V_{1\,\mathrm{km}} = |\Delta V| \cdot \left(\frac{1\ \mathrm{km}}{L}\right)^{1/3}. \tag{5}$$

The scaling is that of the Hong Kong Observatory's glide-path windshear alerting (Section 4): the hazard of a ramp grows with ΔV and falls only slowly with its length. A 15 kt change over 1 km is therefore as significant as 12 kt over 0.5 km, 19 kt over 2 km or 24 kt over 4 km (Fig. 3). The ordinary increase of the wind with height — often 10–15 kt between 1 800 ft and the ground, spread over 8–10 km of approach — stays well below the levels, whereas the same change concentrated in a kilometre or two does not.

A ramp is accepted only when

- the profile has data on at least 60 % of its length;
- the change is **significant**: $|\Delta V| \geq 5\,\sigma\sqrt{1/n_1 + 1/n_2}$, where n_1 and n_2 are the numbers of replies in the two 400-m windows at its ends;
- for a short ramp ($L \leq 600$ m): there are at least three replies at each end, and the headwind does not come back by more than half of the change within the next 400 m — so a single odd stretch of replies cannot raise it.

Only ramps in the **low-level zone** count for alerts: one end below 1 600 ft above the threshold, or within 5 NM of it. (The ICAO layer is 1 600 ft; the 5 NM lets the detector see the final part of the approach where the aircraft are still above 1 600 ft.) For each approach the strongest loss and the strongest gain are kept.

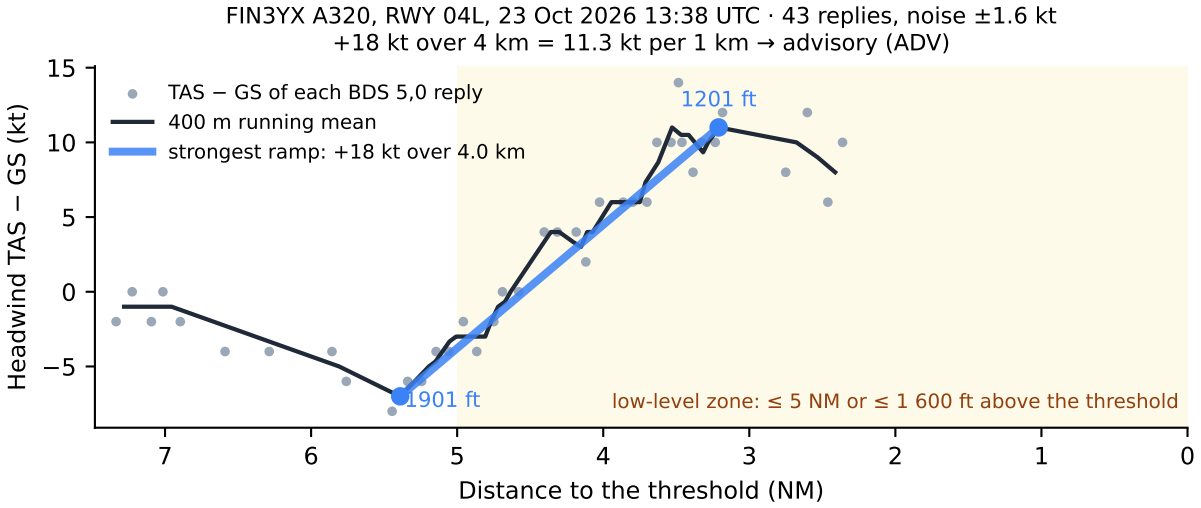


Figure 2. A headwind ramp. Grey dots: TAS − GS of each accepted reply of an A320 approaching runway 04L on 23 October 2026 in a shear layer behind a front; black: the 400-m running mean. Between 5.4 and 3.2 NM from the threshold (1 900 → 1 200 ft) the headwind increased by 18 kt over 4 km, which is 11.3 kt per 1 km: an advisory. Every landing on runways 04L/R in that afternoon showed the same layer (Section 6).

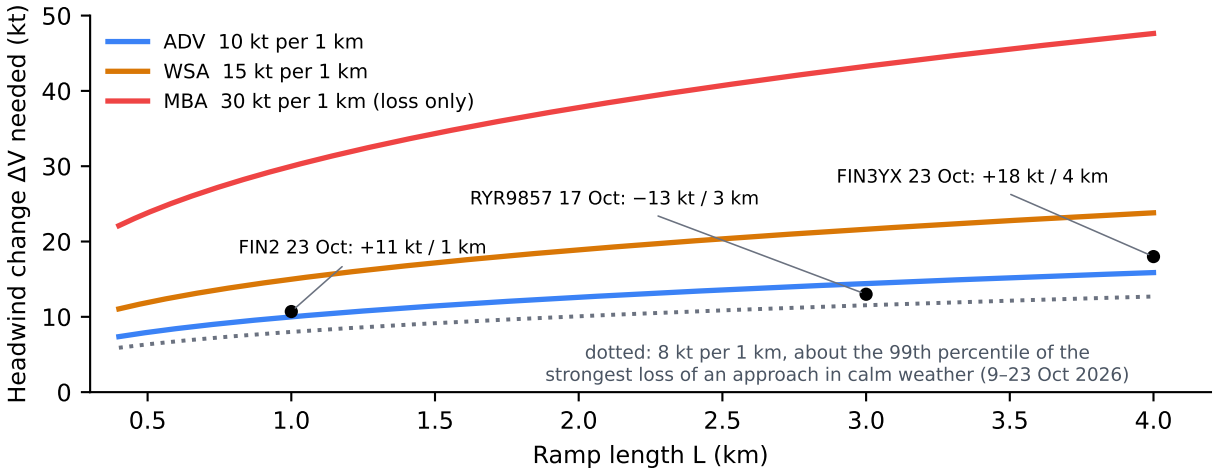


Figure 3. The headwind change a ramp needs to reach each level, as a function of its length. The dotted line is the 99th percentile of the strongest 1-km-equivalent loss of the approaches of 9–23 October 2026, a period of calm weather [12].

3.5 Horizontal F-factor

The same profile gives the horizontal part of the F-factor over 1 km of path: the largest headwind loss over 1 km divided by the time it took to fly it and by g,

$$F_h = -\frac{\bar{h}(x + 1\,\mathrm{km}) - \bar{h}(x)}{g\,\Delta t}. \tag{6}$$

The vertical part ($-w/V$) needs the vertical wind, which cannot be observed from Mode S data, so F_h is a lower bound of the real F. On ordinary approaches at EFHK it is around 0.01 (99 % below 0.03); it is shown in the alert details and

the landing reports but does not set the level. As a reference, airborne windshear systems are designed to warn at a full F of about 0.1–0.13 [5].

3.6 Change against the earlier flights (band comparison)

A single aircraft cannot see a change *in time*: when a front passes, each approach on its own can look smooth while the wind at 1 000 ft has turned completely between two landings. The second part of the detector therefore compares each flight with the flights before it.

For each 200-ft band from 400 to 1 800 ft above mean sea level, the aircraft's wind vector $\mathbf{u}_b$ (the mean of its wind pairs in the band, heading-calibrated) is compared with the **median** wind $\tilde{\mathbf{u}}_b$ of **all landings and departures of the previous 45 minutes, whatever their runway** (at least three of them; the median of the east and north components, so one odd flight does not move it). The difference is taken as a headwind along the aircraft's own direction ψ:

$$a_b = -(\mathbf{u}_b - \tilde{\mathbf{u}}_b) \cdot \hat{\mathbf{e}}_\psi, \qquad \hat{\mathbf{e}}_\psi = (\sin\psi, \cos\psi), \tag{7}$$

so $a_b = -25$ kt means 25 kt *less* headwind than the flights before. The band with the largest $|a_b|$ is reported. Bands with a mean wind above 80 kt or a spread of the wind pairs above 15 kt are left out (corrupt replies); a landing's band needs at least two wind pairs.

Why wind vectors and not TAS − GS here: TAS − GS is the headwind along the flight's own track, so it can only be compared with flights in the same direction. At Helsinki-Vantaa the usual configuration lands on one runway and departs from another (e.g. land 15, depart 22R), and 55 % of the departures had no landing in their own direction within 45 minutes. With wind vectors every flight is a reference for every other: the median approach is compared with 12 earlier flights, and 97 % of the landings have a band comparison.

Departures. Helsinki-Vantaa works in waves; during a departure wave there may be no landing for 20–30 minutes. Each climb-out is therefore compared in the same way, and becomes a reference for the next 45 minutes. Its runway is found from the first position and the initial climb track (track within 25° of a runway direction, first position within 1 NM of that runway's extended centreline); climb-outs after a go-around are not used. A departure climbs four to five times as steeply as a 3° approach, so a band may rest on a single wind pair; such a band gets a level only when a neighbouring band (±200 ft) shows a change of at least 10 kt in the same direction. Departures give band alerts only, no ramps (the acceleration on the climb-out makes TAS − GS harder to interpret).

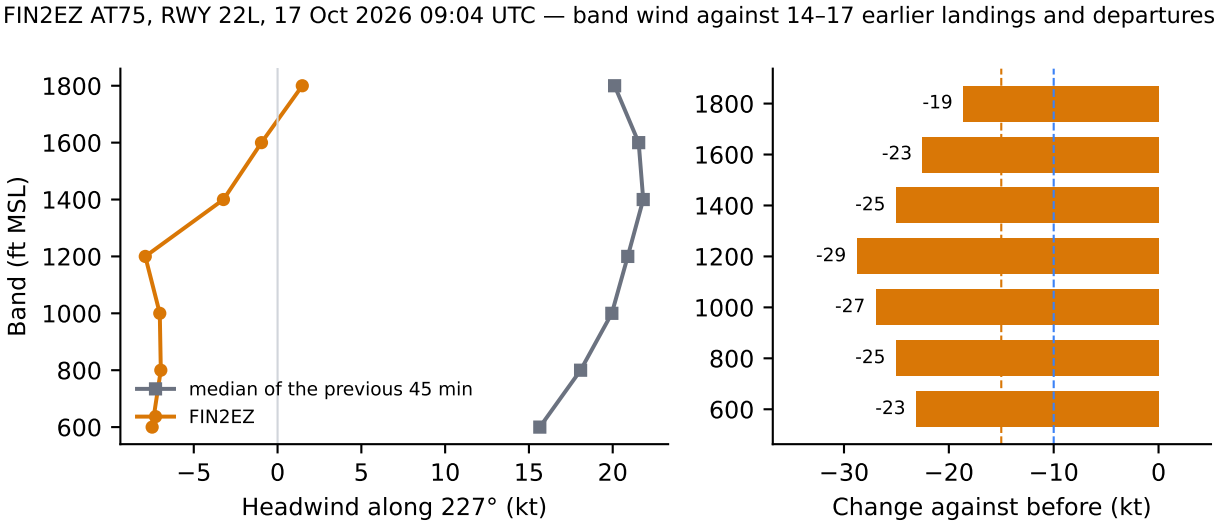


Figure 4. The band comparison of FIN2EZ on 17 October 2026. Left: the headwind along runway 22L in each band, FIN2EZ (orange) and the median of the 14–17 flights of the previous 45 minutes (grey). Right: the difference. At 1 200 ft the wind was 334°/27 kt instead of about 220°/21 kt: 29 kt less headwind than before — a windshear alert (WSA), although the approach itself was smooth (no ramp above the noise).

3.7 Levels

The names follow the runway-oriented alerts of the US airport windshear systems (LLWAS and TDWR), where a *wind shear alert* is a headwind loss of 15–29 kt or a gain of 15 kt or more, and a *microburst alert* a loss of 30 kt or more [9]. MODE-S Wind adds an advisory level below them.

Table 1. Alert levels.

Level	Badge	Ramp (1-km equivalent)	Band change	Colour
WS advisory	ADV	$\geq$ 10 kt, loss or gain	$\geq$ 10 kt (headwind along the flight)	blue
Windshear alert	WSA	$\geq$ 15 kt, loss or gain	$\geq$ 15 kt	amber
Microburst alert	MBA	$\geq$ 30 kt, **loss** only	—	red

3.8 From an event to an alert

The live analysis runs whenever new replies of an aircraft have arrived — about every 3 s, with each sweep of the tracker. Each analysis gives its *events*: a ramp loss, a ramp gain or a band change at some level. An event becomes an **alert** when it is found in **two analyses in a row**, so a single bad reply cannot raise one. The alert stays active for 10 minutes after it was last seen and is then removed. If it escalates (advisory → WSA) it is logged again; a stronger value at the same level updates the log entry. The server keeps the alert log of the last 24 hours (at most 100 entries) in memory, so it is shown also when the page was closed, and writes a short line to its log file for every new alert.

3.9 A windshear report for every flight

When a landing is recorded, the whole analysis is run once more over the complete final approach and stored with the landing: the replies used and their noise, the strongest loss and gain ramps with their heights and distances, the horizontal F-factor, the band comparison and the overall level. Each departure gets its band comparison. These reports are shown in the Approach History (Section 5.3). When the server starts, older landings that still have their raw replies (kept 90 days) and the stored departures get their report in the background, in time order, so that each flight is compared with the flights before it.

4 The scientific basis

The ramp method. The Hong Kong Observatory (HKO) alerts windshear at Hong Kong International Airport, where terrain-disrupted airflow causes frequent windshear, with a Doppler lidar that scans along the glide paths. Its glide-path algorithm (GLYGA) builds a headwind profile along each approach and departure path and looks for *ramps*: headwind changes over lengths of 400 m to 4 km, ranked by $\Delta V/L^{1/3}$ [6, 3]. The form of this criterion comes from earlier analyses of aircraft flight-data recorders, in which windshear encounters were identified from the headwind along the flight path [6, 3] (the methods of Woodfield and Woods, 1983, and Jones and Haynes, 1984, as cited there); HKO describes the severity of a ramp as primarily a function of $\Delta V/L^{1/3}$ [8]. Chan, Hon and Shin added short-scale gradients to the ramps and caught 5–10 % more of the pilot-reported windshear [7]; Hon and Chan showed that removing "gentle ramps" — long, smooth headwind changes that exceed the threshold only because of their length — cuts false alerts [8].

MODE-S Wind applies the same idea to a different sensor. Instead of a lidar profile along the glide path at one instant, it uses the profile measured by each aircraft itself as it flies down the path. Two differences follow: the aircraft sees the air along its own path only (not the whole path at once), and its profile is available only after it has flown through the air. In return, every equipped aircraft is a sensor, also in rain and fog where a lidar is blind, and no equipment at the airport is needed. The ramp lengths (0.4–4 km) are those of GLYGA; the 1-km normalisation, the 15 kt alert level, the significance test and the persistence test of short ramps are choices of MODE-S Wind, fitted to the noise of the Mode S data.

The hazard index. The F-factor and its 1-km averaging length come from the NASA/FAA windshear programme [4, 5]. The horizontal part can be computed from the same profile; the downdraft part cannot, which is why F_h is reported for information and does not set the level.

The alert levels follow the ground-based systems: LLWAS and TDWR alert on the runway-oriented headwind change, with the 15 kt and 30 kt (loss) limits of Table 1 [9], and 15 kt is the common definition of significant windshear [2, 3].

The comparison between flights has no direct precedent that I know of. It is closest to the idea of using aircraft reports as objective windshear observations ("automated pilot reports"), which HKO pursues with flight data from airline quick-access recorders [10], and to LLWAS, which compares the wind at different places at the same time; here the wind at the same place is compared at different times.

Mode S data for windshear. Wind and temperature derived from Mode S Enhanced Surveillance have been studied mainly for weather forecasting [11]. A restudy of the MODE-S Wind data in October 2026 found no published work that detects low-level windshear from passively received Mode S replies; the Hong Kong Observatory has noted that the low latency and high sampling rate of Mode S winds make them suitable in principle for real-time windshear alerting [12]. The restudy also measured the noise floor of TAS − GS and replayed 3 084 landings, which led to the design described here and to the retirement of the six earlier browser algorithms (their description is kept in the guide *Windshear detection v1 — retired algorithms*).

Table 2. MODE-S Wind among windshear sensors (simplified).

Sensor	Measures	Strength	Limitation
LLWAS (anemometers)	surface wind around the runways	continuous, direct	surface only, fixed points
Doppler radar (TDWR)	radial wind in precipitation	microbursts in rain	weak in dry air
Doppler lidar (HKO)	radial wind in clear air, along the glide path	whole path at once	blind in heavy rain and fog
Airborne (reactive / predictive)	the aircraft's own F-factor / radar ahead	on board, certified	one aircraft, at the moment
MODE-S Wind	headwind along each aircraft's path, wind per band	every aircraft, any weather, no airport equipment	after the fact, only where aircraft fly, no downdraft

5 The Windshear page

The Windshear page follows the aircraft on final approach and shows the results of the detection. Figure 5 shows it during the wind change of 17 October 2026 (Section 6).



Figure 5. The Windshear page, reconstructed for 17 October 2026 09:05 UTC from the stored data of that morning (the live alert state is not stored, so it was rebuilt from the detector's results; the Approach History, the statistics and the map are the real page on the stored database). (1) alert banner, (2) flight strips with the WS badge, (3) map with the approach centrelines, (4) Approach History in WS mode, (5) Wind Rose / ACI panel, (6) ILS profile with the alert bands, (7) Windshear Alert log with the alert-level selector, (8) Today's statistics, (9) METAR and TAF.

5.1 Banner, flight strips and ILS profile

The **alert-level selector** in the header of the Windshear Alert panel (Banner off / ADV ≥10 kt / WSA ≥15 kt / MBA ≥30 kt; default WSA, remembered in the browser) sets the lowest level that is shown in three places:

- the **alert banner** at the top of the page, one entry per active alert, e.g. `WSA · RWY 22L · 29 kt ▼LOSS · at 1200 ft vs the last 45 min [FIN2EZ]` for a band change, or `ADV · RWY 04L · 18 kt ▲GAIN · over 4.0 km, 1901→1201 ft [FIN3YX]` for a ramp; the heading reads `WINDSHEAR ADVISORY`, `WINDSHEAR ALERT` or `MICROBURST ALERT` after the highest level shown. Departures are marked `departure`;
- the **WS badge** on the aircraft's flight strip (Fig. 6): ADV blue, WSA amber and MBA red, the last two pulsing;
- a coloured band on the **ILS profile** over the height range of the alert (the ramp from its start to its end height, or the 200-ft band of a band change), labelled e.g. `WSA 29kt▼`.



Figure 6. Banner and flight strips. RYR9857 on 22L at 3.4 NM carries a WSA badge; its strip shows the wind 333°/26 kt, i.e. a 7 kt tailwind for runway 22L, where the flights 20 minutes earlier had a headwind of about 20 kt. FIN2AT, behind it, has no alert yet.

5.2 The alert log

The **Windshear Alert** log lists the alerts of the last 24 hours (and the go-arounds seen while the page is open), newest first, one line each: time, level, runway (`dep` for a departure), change with ▼ loss or ▲ gain, the ramp length (`1.2km`) or the band (`@1200ft`), and the callsign. The log always shows all levels, whatever the selector says. Hovering an entry gives the details (Fig. 7): for a band change the reference headwind and the number of earlier flights, for a ramp the heights and distances of its ends, the 1-km equivalent and the horizontal F-factor. Clear hides the entries in this browser only; ⓘ v2 opens the description of the retired algorithms.

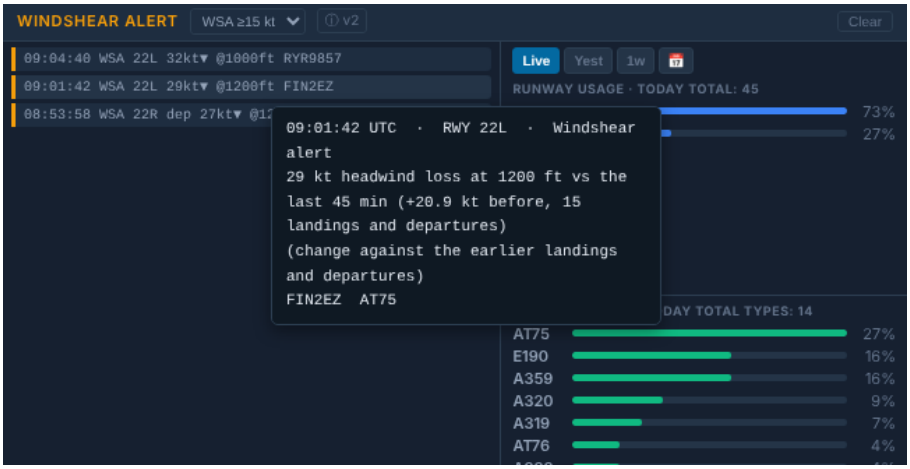


Figure 7. The alert log of 17 October with the details of the FIN2EZ alert: 29 kt headwind loss at 1 200 ft, against +20.9 kt in the 15 landings and departures of the previous 45 minutes. The first entry of the morning is the departure FIN863 at 08:54 (`22R dep`).

5.3 Approach History: the WS view

The Apch Hist button opens the Approach History, one row per landing. Its display selector has six views: the wind per height band (Wind, HW, XW, HW+XW), the Approach Conditions Index (ACI, Section 5.4) and the windshear report (WS, Fig. 8). The WS view has seven columns:

Column	Content
Level	ADV / WSA / MBA of the landing, — for none
Loss, Gain	the strongest ramp each way, as `7 kt/3.0` = 7 kt over 3.0 km; coloured by its level when in the low-level zone
F 1km	horizontal F-factor over 1 km
Band Δ	the largest change of a band against the previous 45 minutes, e.g. `−29 @1200`; coloured by its level
Low	the lowest height followed (ft MSL)
n	replies used, with the noise (± kt)

Hovering a row shows the whole report. For FIN2EZ (Fig. 8) it reads: *Windshear report — Windshear alert · Strongest loss: none above the noise · Band 1200 ft: −28.8 kt against 20.9 kt in the last 45 min (15 landings and departures) · Followed … 40 replies, noise ±1.3 kt.* Landings without stored raw replies (contact lost early, or before 24 October 2026 without a series) show —.



Figure 8. Approach History, WS view, 17 October 2026. The landings on 22L until 08:54 had small band changes (−3 to −7 kt) and a few 3–4 km ramps of 6–9 kt (the normal increase of the wind with height, well below the advisory level); FIN2EZ at 09:04 had −29 kt at 1 200 ft.

5.4 The other panels

ILS profile and wind barbs. The profile shows every aircraft on final against the 3° glide path (corrected for the QNH and the threshold elevation), with its trail. Barbs draws the winds measured by one aircraft (a clicked strip, or Auto: the lowest one) along its approach, HW / XW add the head- and crosswind components, and the METAR wind is drawn at the threshold. Comparing the barbs of successive aircraft is the quickest way to see a ramp or a change between flights for yourself.

Wind Rose. Compares the METAR surface wind (cyan) with the mean wind of the approaches of the last 30 minutes below 2 000 ft (green); Hist shows how the low-level wind direction has drifted over the last 3 or 6 hours.

Approach Conditions Index (ACI). The ACI button of the same panel plots one dot per landing: an index from 0 (smooth) to 10 (very rough) of how much the aircraft was moved on final (Fig. 9). It is built from the quick fluctuations of airspeed (45 %), vertical rate (30 %) and bank angle (25 %) — each the RMS about a ±7.5 s running median, so the slow, planned changes of an approach are removed — scaled between a calm and a rough reference, averaged over the segments 3 000–1 000 and 1 000–200 ft, and divided by a class factor (turboprops 1.5, business jets 1.25, regional jets 1.15, narrow- and widebodies 1.0) because light aircraft are moved more by the same air. Levels: below 2 *Smooth*, 2–4 *Light*, 4–6 *Choppy*, 6–8 *Rough*, from 8 *Very rough*. The ACI is not part of the windshear detection and not a turbulence report: it measures the aircraft's response (including the autopilot or the pilot), but it follows the surface wind well (median about 1 at 0–8 kt, 3 at 9–12 kt, 4.3 at 13–16 kt) and is a useful companion to the windshear alerts on a gusty day. It is still provisional.



Figure 9. The ACI view of the Wind Rose panel on the morning of 17 October 2026: one dot per landing, coloured by aircraft class, with the running median (green). The wind change did not make the approaches rough (median 1.9, *Smooth*): windshear and turbulence are different things.

Go-arounds. The tracker detects a go-around from a sustained climb on final (or a climb after crossing the threshold) and logs it with the alerts (· `GA 22L`); a returning aircraft gets a `2nd APP` badge. A go-around shortly after a windshear alert is worth a closer look.

Today's statistics show the runway use, the go-arounds and the aircraft types of today, yesterday or the last week; the **METAR / TAF** strip shows the latest reports. A METAR wind that does not change while the alerts come is normal: the surface wind is measured at 10 m, the windshear is often several hundred feet higher.

6 Cases from October 2026

17 October 2026: a wind change at 1 000 ft. A cold front lay over southern Finland. Until 08:50 UTC the landings on 22L had a steady south-westerly headwind of about 20 kt at 1 000–1 200 ft. At 08:54 the departure FIN863 from 22R found 26 kt less headwind at 1 200 ft than the flights before it — a windshear alert, ten minutes before the next landing. From 09:04 the landings FIN2EZ, RYR9857 and FIN2AT each had 29–32 kt less headwind at 1 000–1 200 ft (Fig. 10); the wind there had turned from about 220° to 330°. The METAR hardly changed (220°/9 kt at 08:50, low cloud at 400 ft), and none of the approaches had a ramp above 10 kt per 1 km: each aircraft flew through a smooth profile, only a different one from its predecessors. From 09:13 the departures moved to runway 04 and saw the reversed wind (20–38 kt more headwind than the 22 departures before them). This is exactly the case the band comparison was made for.

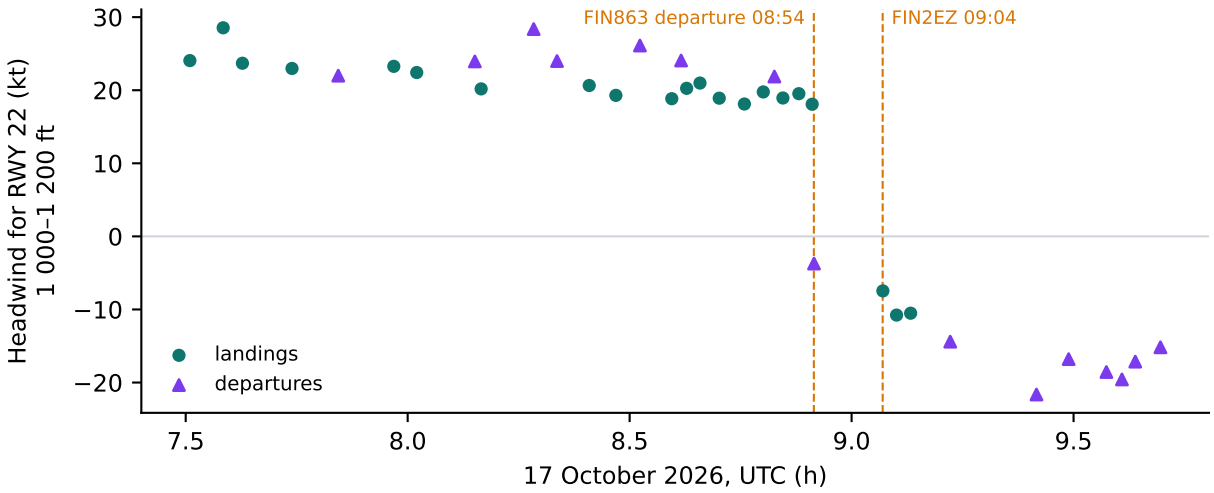


Figure 10. 17 October 2026: the headwind for runway 22 at 1 000–1 200 ft of every landing (green) and departure (violet) between 07:30 and 09:45 UTC, from their band wind vectors. The change arrived with the departure FIN863 at 08:54; the landings from 09:04 had a tailwind.

23 October 2026: a shear layer behind a front. On the afternoon of 23 October (11:30–14:15 UTC) every landing on 04L/R passed through a persistent shear layer at about 1 400–1 800 ft, with about 8 kt of tailwind above it and 10 kt of headwind below. Seven landings gave a ramp advisory (gains of 11–18 kt over 1–4 km, 1-km equivalent 10–11 kt; Fig. 2); none reached an alert, and the runway changes 04 → 15 → 22 during the frontal passage caused no false alarms.

Results so far. Table 3 summarises the stored reports of 9–24 October 2026. The weather was calm or moderate (the highest METAR wind 17 kt) and no windshear was reported at EFHK, so these numbers are mainly a false-alarm check; the levels still have to be confirmed in strong-wind and convective weather.

Table 3. Windshear reports 9–24 October 2026.

	Landings	Departures
Flights with a report	3 310	3 084
Ramp advisories (ADV)	38 (1.1 %)	—
Ramp alerts (WSA, MBA)	0	—
Band advisories (ADV)	0	21 (0.7 %)
Band alerts (WSA)	4 (0.12 %)	9 (0.3 %)
Noise of TAS − GS (median)	1.24 kt	
Lowest height followed (median)	476 ft MSL	
Horizontal F-factor over 1 km	median 0.011, max 0.047	
Earlier flights in the band comparison (median)	12	

Three of the four landing alerts and six of the nine departure alerts belong to the 17 October case (FIN863 and the five runway-04 departures of 09:13–09:34); two departure alerts came on 13 October and one at 04:42 UTC on 24 October during a night-time frontal passage, with 16 kt more headwind at 1 800 ft than the flights before.

7 Limitations and good practice

- **After the fact, and only where aircraft fly.** Every value describes air an aircraft has already flown through. An alert warns the *next* aircraft only if the shear persists — often for fronts and low-level jets, rarely for a short-lived microburst. Between flights nothing is measured.
- **Not the whole approach.** The data usually end at 300–500 ft above the runway, where windshear is most dangerous; the last part of the approach is not seen.
- **Scale.** Changes over less than about 400 m are smoothed out by design; the typical size of the events that trigger on-board reactive warnings, a few hundred metres, is at the resolution limit of the data.
- **No downdraft.** The vertical wind cannot be observed, so microburst downdrafts appear only through their horizontal outflow and the F-factor is a lower bound.
- **Slow changes.** The band comparison uses the last 45 minutes as its reference: a change that builds up gradually over an hour is absorbed by it.
- **Quality of the wind vectors.** The band winds rest on the heading calibration (about 3–4 kt of noise per band); a departure band often rests on one or two wind pairs.
- **The levels are first values.** They were set on calm weather and one moderate front; they will be reviewed with strong-wind and convective cases.

Good practice. Read an alert together with its details (hover), the flights before and after it in the Approach History and the barbs on the ILS profile. Several aircraft in a row with the same change make it real; a single flight with a band change resting on one wind pair is a hint. Compare with the METAR, and in summer with the weather radar.

8 Quick reference

Parameter	Value
Headwind (ramps)	TAS − GS of each BDS 5,0 reply; dropped: roll $> 5°$, repeated register (< 6 s), > 12 kt off the ± 7.5 s median
Distance	ground speed integrated over time (not positions)
Smoothing	400 m running mean on a 100 m grid
Ramp lengths	0.4, 0.6, 0.8, 1, 1.5, 2, 3, 4 km; ≥ 60 % data coverage
Significance	$\lvert\Delta V\rvert \geq 5\sigma\sqrt{1/n_1 + 1/n_2}$; short ramps ($\leq 600$ m): ≥ 3 replies at each end and persistent over the next 400 m
Scaling	$V_{1\,\mathrm{km}} = \lvert\Delta V\rvert\,(1\,\mathrm{km}/L)^{1/3}$
Low-level zone	below 1 600 ft above the threshold or within 5 NM
Horizontal F-factor	largest headwind loss over 1 km / $(g\,\Delta t)$; information only
Band comparison	200-ft bands 400–1 800 ft MSL; median wind of all flights of the last 45 min (any runway, ≥ 3); headwind change along the flight's direction
Band quality	landing ≥ 2 wind pairs; departure single-pair band needs a neighbour ≥ 10 kt the same way; bands > 80 kt or spread > 15 kt dropped
Departure runway	initial track within 25° of a runway, first position ≤ 1 NM from its centreline
Levels	ADV ≥ 10 kt, WSA ≥ 15 kt, MBA ≥ 30 kt loss (ramps only)
Alerts	2 analyses in a row; held 10 min after last seen; log 24 h / 100 entries
Stored	`approach_history.shear_json`, `departure_profiles.shear_json` (report version 3)
API	`/api/windshear/state`: `ws_events`, `ws_log`; `/api/windshear/approach-history`: `shear`

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